

Lesson 3

What Actually Works

Most people will reach a point where nothing they are doing is working anymore. The research, the checking and monitoring, the specialists, the protocols, the supplements, it all starts to feel like I am running in place. You're probably there, and if you are there, I want you to know that that's not really a bad sign.

What I have found is that's usually where the actual shift starts. It's kind of like rock bottom is a great launching pad. Most people have to run out of other options before they are willing to implement what I am teaching you in this course. I hit a wall after about a year of making myself worse. I was sitting in another neurologist's office getting another prescription I did not want, and realizing.

This person has nothing to offer me. The medical system has nothing to offer me, and I just knew I'm done. I'm not, I'm not doing this anymore. I had ran out of options, and that was when something really shifted inside of me. That was when I knew it was time for me to apply all of the principles that I had learned when I was obsessively consuming all of this content and seeing what everyone was talking about over and over again and going all in.

On believing that a mind body approach to healing all of this was the path for me, but there were behaviors that were gonna need to stop. So the behaviors that you feel are helping you, researching, checking, asking for reassurance, and organizing your entire day and your life around your symptoms, those are the same behaviors that are keeping the alarm running.

I don't care whether you like that or not. Trust me. I hate that it works this way, but those things are what is keeping this loop alive. And every time you do them, your nervous system is registering it. It is learning and rewiring. In that moment, we're still frantically looking for answers, so we must still be in a lot of danger.

So I stopped the constant researching. I stopped all of it. I stopped letting my symptoms decide what my schedule for the day was, and I didn't do this perfectly, but my direction completely changed, which was exactly what I needed. So what replaces all of that time you were spending, researching, and learning and, and fixing?

For me around that time when that shift was made, I started working with a coach whose primary focus was OCD and anxiety based. Looking back, I am so grateful that I found that path. It wasn't work that I was expecting, but it was exactly what I needed to desensitize my system. It wasn't super gentle or soothing.

It was actually pretty direct. And oftentimes uncomfortable. But the core of it was that I needed to stop the compulsive behaviors. I had to stop seeking reassurance, checking and realizing that every time I do these things, I'm teaching my nervous system that it cannot handle uncertainty or ever having an open loop.

What I have found is that this specific approach in this way is rarely applied to chronic physical symptoms, and it is rarely talked about in the mind, body world, and I think it is essential. We are not talking enough about when this moves from fear to obsession. And that's where the OCD component was very helpful for me to understand because I was obsessively focusing on my body, on my symptoms, on fixing.

It had moved so far past fear, and that was due to the severe sensitization of the system moving far beyond dysregulation. And one of my early coaching calls with this coach, after I had been avoiding the work that I needed to do, I got a wake up call because he told me, if you do not stop all of these things that you are doing compulsively, you're going to be hitting me up in four years, melting down and in a much worse off position than you are now.

That was a huge wake up call for me, and I hope hearing it now is a huge wake up call for you as well. There is a reason why this works. When I finally understood that the nervous system learns from what you do, how you behave, and how you respond, I realized that it was gonna be the quickest way for me to signal to my nervous system.

Whether I was living in a place of safety or a place of danger. Every time you react with urgency, you're reinforcing that something is wrong. I know I am being repetitive. That is on purpose because if you understand that, you're gonna understand that on the flip side, every time you let a sensation be there without checking or researching or trying to fix it, you are teaching it something different.

You are rewiring your brain. You are teaching it safety. In those moments, it's what I like to call you are showing it safety versus just telling it, I'm safe, I'm safe, I'm safe, which doesn't work. By the way, what I found after applying this work in this way was that my baseline was slowly starting to lower.

It was not instant, but finally things had stopped escalating and started moving in the right direction. I wanna be very honest and direct with you here. This was not a comfortable process. Most of this process will not be, I would've rather been journaling or sticking my feet up a wall or visualizing my future, but we both know that those things don't work when you are severely sensitized.

We can do that stuff later. Once we get you a little bit more desensitized, so when you're doing this, you're gonna feel irresponsible. Your symptoms are not going to instantly vanish, and there are going to be days where you are completely overcome with doubt, and all you want is just to go back to that compulsive behavior just so you can feel a little better and feel like you're doing something or moving in the right direction.

And to be honest with you, oftentimes you will. You will do it. It will be part of falling into these old behavior patterns. It's normal. It's okay, and what we're trying to do is shift the scales so that you're

doing that less and less, because that in and of itself is a different response, but your relationship to your symptoms is going to change first before the symptoms.

Do if you are doing these things expecting one of two things, like is it working? Are my symptoms going down? That's not the way we're going to be judging success, especially because things can go in the opposite direction. Things can move and shift and increase and freak out because you know what?

That's what sensitized systems do. The system is going a bit haywire, especially when you start responding differently because you're starting to send this new signal that your nervous system is not used to. It's use to the panic, it's use to the cortisol and the adrenaline and the fear, and sometimes the reaction it has to the changed response is it goes a little bit more haywire.

The first thing that you're going to be working on recovering from is the chronic fear. Because while I know you're suffering from chronic symptoms, the main symptom is chronic fear. The symptoms are gonna go later, but the shift in fear is what is going to change everything for you. This is not something you can force or speed up.

It is going to happen slowly over time. With repetition and consistency, which is what is challenging about this process, when you stop reacting the way that you have been for so long and you stop chasing certainty, and when you let discomfort be there without needing it to go away instantly. You rewire your brain.

You rewire these circuits and you unlearn the circuits that are driving the symptoms. In the next lesson, I wanna talk about the skill that this actually requires, which is the ability to feel uncomfortable without needing that feeling to stop.